

Conditional Formatting

Learning Objectives

- Apply color scales to visualize data ranges
- Use data bars and icon sets for quick analysis
- Create custom rules for highlighting specific cells

Engage (5-7 minutes)

Think of a traffic light—green means go, yellow means slow, red means stop. Conditional formatting works like traffic lights for data—colors change automatically based on values, making it easy to spot patterns, problems, and highlights at a glance.

Explore (10-12 minutes)

Enter student marks in B1:B20. Select the range. Go to Format > Conditional Formatting. Apply a Color Scale: green for high marks, yellow for medium, red for low. Add Data Bars to see relative performance visually. Try Icon Sets (arrows or traffic lights). Observe how colors change with different values.

Explain (10-12 minutes)

Conditional formatting applies styles based on cell values. Color scales use gradients (green-yellow-red) to show value distribution. Data bars add colored bars proportional to values. Icon sets add symbols (arrows, flags) for categories. You can create custom rules like “highlight cells greater than 80” with specific colors.

Elaborate (8-10 minutes)

Apply conditional formatting to a temperature data set (30 values). Use color scale for hot-cold visualization. Create a rule to highlight temperatures above 40 in red. Add data bars to monthly rainfall data. Write which visualization method best shows extreme values and why.

Evaluate (5-8 minutes)

Answer: When is conditional formatting more useful than just reading numbers? Create a rule to highlight names starting with ‘A’ in blue. What is the difference between color scales and data bars?